Lupus

Abi Harrison-Nye

Symptoms

- Extreme fatigue that doesn't improve with rest or sleep.
- Pain and swelling in the joints, often accompanied by stiffness.
- A characteristic 'butterfly' rash across the cheeks and bridge of the nose.

Age & Gender

- Most commonly diagnosed in females between the ages of 15 and 45.
- Females are nine times more likely to develop the condition than males.

Common myths

- It’s not a contagious disease.
- It’s not just a skin condition, as it can affect internal organs.
- It’s not predictable, with symptoms fluctuating between wellness and severe flares.

Diagnosis

- Blood tests check for specific antibodies suggesting an autoimmune response.
- Urine tests and biopsies monitor whether the condition is affecting the kidneys.

Treatment

- Anti-inflammatory drugs and antimalarials help manage pain and skin issues.
- Immunosuppressants are used in more severe cases to stop self-attack.

How to help

- Limit exposure to bright lights which can trigger flares.
- Offer flexible deadlines to accommodate sudden, severe fatigue.
- Position workstations away from direct heat or intense light.

This information isn't a diagnostic tool. If you recognise these symptoms in yourself or others, please contact a doctor.

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